COMMUNICATION GAP



At Rahul Gandhi's much-publicised presser on the alleged "vote *chori*" in Karnataka's Mahadevapura seat, one absence was glaring—Congress communications chief and Kannadiga **Jairam Ramesh**. Insiders say the Rajya Sabha MP was miffed at being excluded from the months-long scrutiny of electoral rolls in his home state. He was apparently informed only just before Rahul went public. Even Karnataka CM Siddaramaiah and his deputy D.K. Shivakumar were reportedly out of the loop.

WELL-GUARDED SHOW



Peeved that Andhra Pradesh CM N. Chandrababu Naidu was not providing enough security on his district tours, YSRC chief **Y.S. Jagan Mohan Reddy** has stepped it up on his own. Since August 6, besides the state-provided Z-plus security, he also has 40 personal guards, including 10 ex–army personnel. The party claims it is to regulate the crowds gathering to greet Jagan at his public appearances. Strange, since the ex-CM is known to thrive on such exchanges.

WHIP CRACK



The TMC's veteran Lok Sabha chief whip **Kalyan Banerjee** quit soon after party chief Mamata Banerjee made nephew Abhishek party leader in the House. But it wasn't the latter's rise that stung Kalyan. It was Mamata's reported lament that MPs weren't "coordinating", perhaps a veiled jibe at Kalyan who has had a running feud with a couple of party MPs. For a man who'd long tended the flock, the jab cut deep. "If Didi feels I'm not doing well, I quit," he said. Mamata promptly accepted it, installing four-time MP Kakoli G. Dastidar in his place.

Kaushik Deka with Jumana Shah, Arkamoy Datta Majumdar and Amarnath K. Menon

ECO WATCH

By **Jumana Shah**

HISS HISS HURRAY
BABY KINGS RELEASED



As tribal chants echoed softly in the forest, 30 King Cobra (Ophiophagus hannah) hatchlings were released in the dense areas near Valabu village in Alluri Sitarama Raju district in Paderu division of the Eastern Ghats, marking the first community-led initiative of its kind in Andhra Pradesh. As forest trackers updated that the hatchlings were dispersing, some already hunting, the tribal village celebrated quietly, knowing their efforts had revived a predator vital to the ecosystem. This paves the way for a proposed 2,400 ha. king cobra sanctuary, which, if established, would be the world's first, making Andhra as a leader in species-specific conservation.

GRASSLAND AS CARBON SINK



A recent study cited in *Scientific Reports* reveals that Gujarat's 2,600 sq. km Banni grassland, purportedly Asia's largest, is a highly effective carbon sink. Researchers from the KSKV Kachchh University and others highlighted Banni's ability to sequester significant amounts of carbon dioxide, crucial for mitigating climate change. Between 2019 and 2022, the grassland absorbed an average 136 grams of carbon per sq. m annually, comparable to some forest ecosystems. Unlike forests, which store carbon primarily above ground, Banni's carbon is predominantly sequestered in its soil, with 90 per cent stored underground in dense root systems and organic matter. Banni supports over 40 grass species and also sustains pastoral communities, apt measures of its ecological and cultural significance.